

Sorted design philosophy: Modern Finance Tape

Sorted is a privacy-first Android money app for India. It reads payment alerts from SMS and Gmail on the phone, sorts them into categories, and shows the user their month. No bank login, no cloud copy.

For product, design and engineering. Everything here is a rule you can check a screen against.

READS LIKE

A modern money app

PROVES LIKE

A printed tape of payments

UNDERSTOOD IN

3 seconds on Home

LIVES ONLY

On this phone

1. Core thesis

Sorted feels like a clean modern finance app on the surface and a private money tape underneath. The surface answers fast. The tape lets the user check any number down to the payment that made it.

Three commitments follow from that, and they never bend:

- **Payments are the truth.** Every total is a sum of payments the user can open and read.
- **Only spending is spending.** Transfers, investments, refunds, rewards and income are counted apart from spending, never inside it.
- **Doubt is shown calmly.** When Sorted is unsure, it says so in one amber mark and offers one tap to fix it. It never guesses quietly and it never panics.

The test: a user glances at Home and knows how much they spent, where it went, what needs review, and what happened recently — without reading a sentence.

2. Product personality

Sorted is the quiet, careful friend who keeps good records. It is never a coach, never a cheerleader, never a warning light.

IS

Calm · precise · plain-spoken · private ·
checkable · one-handed · fast to read · patient
with mistakes

IS NOT

Playful · gamified · scolding · chatty · clever ·
dense · accountant-flavoured · begging for
attention

3. Visual principles

1. **One number owns the screen.** The month's spend is the largest thing on Home by a wide margin. Nothing competes with it.
2. **Rules instead of boxes.** Sections are separated by hairlines and paper tone changes, not by stacks of rounded cards.
3. **Printed rhythm.** Rows repeat at a steady height with aligned numbers, so the eye scans down a column like a printed strip.
4. **Paper, lightly.** Warm off-white surface, faint ruled lines, a perforated edge at the top of a month. Texture stays under 6% contrast — a cue, not a costume.
5. **Amber is the only interruption.** A stamp-like amber mark means "needs you". It appears at most twice per screen.
6. **Bars, not pies.** Share of spending is a plain horizontal bar with the percentage in type. No donuts, no gradients, no neon.
7. **Room at the bottom.** The most-used actions and the first thing the thumb reaches sit in the lower half of the screen.

4. UX principles

1. **Every total is a door.** Tapping any amount, percentage or count opens the payments behind it, already filtered.
2. **One tap to correct.** Wrong category, wrong amount, not a payment — each is fixed from the row itself, then the totals update in place.
3. **Review is a short pile, not a chore.** Sorted shows how many need review, never a queue that scrolls forever. Finish and the screen empties with a quiet stamp.
4. **Nothing disappears silently.** Anything not counted as spending is still visible under "Not counted", with the reason in two words.
5. **Teach by doing.** Fixing one payment offers to make it a rule. Auto-sorting rules are written from real corrections, never from a blank form.
6. **Privacy is stated once, gently.** A single line — "Stays on this phone" — plus a clear page in Settings. No badges on every screen.
7. **Empty and broken states still answer the four questions.** No payments yet, imports paused, alerts missing: say what is known, what is missing, and the one action that fixes it.

5. Information hierarchy

Home is ordered by the four questions, in this order, always. Anything that is not one of these four earns its place elsewhere.

RANK	QUESTION	WHAT SHOWS	WEIGHT
1	How much did I spend?	Spent this month, payment count	56px, 600
2	What needs review?	Amber stamp with a count, tappable	12px stamp
3	Where did it go?	Top spending — three categories, bars, percent	14.5px rows
4	What happened recently?	Recent spending — four to six payments	15.5px rows
5	Is anything left out?	Not counted — one line with a count	12px, muted

Below the fold, nothing new is introduced — only more of the same list. Months, search and settings live in the bottom bar.

6. Language rules

Sentence case. Short. Familiar money words, the kind used in conversation. No accounting or system vocabulary, ever — if a word needs explaining, it is the wrong word.

SAY	NEVER SAY	WHY
Spent this month	Total outflow, debits	Money words, not statement words
Payments	Lines, entries, records	A payment is a thing that happened
Need review	Unstamped, query, pending action	Says who acts and what for
Not counted	Held out, excluded, out of scope	Plain and neutral
Top spending	Category breakdown, spend mix	Everyday phrasing
Recent spending	Latest activity feed	Matches the section above it
Imports	Sources, source health, sync	Describes what the user set up
Edit transaction	Amend, restamp, reclassify	Ordinary app language
Auto-sorting rules	Ledger rules, mapping logic	Says what it does for the user
Stays on this phone	On-device, zero-knowledge, E2E	Privacy in words anyone believes

Shape rules. Section labels are two words, uppercase, small. Row labels are the merchant's name as it arrived. Buttons are verbs: Review, Edit, Add, Keep, Not spending. Amounts always carry ₹ and thousands separators, never decimals on Home.

Uncertainty phrasing. Say what is unclear, in one line: "Amount unclear", "New place — which category?", "Looks like a transfer". Never an error tone, never an apology, never a paragraph.

7. Colour and material direction

 Paper #FAF7F1 Main surface	 Tape #F2EDE3 Banded sections, bottom bar	 Ink #07264C Amounts, headings, bar 1	 Muted #58728D Labels, meta, inactive tabs
 Blue #305EFF Links, selection, bar 2	 Amber #B45A09 Needs review only (#D9821A dot)		

- Ink carries every number. Muted carries every label. Amber carries nothing but review.
- Material cues, in order of use: hairline rules (1px ink at 8–10%), a tape band in #F2EDE3, ruled lines behind long lists at 4.5%, a perforated dotted edge at a month boundary, a dashed amber stamp outline rotated 1–2°.
- Green appears only on money coming back — refunds, rewards, income — never on spending.
- No shadows except a single soft one on a sheet that slides over content. No gradients, no glass, no glow.
- Dark mode is night paper: ink #E8EEF6 on #14181F, tape band #1B212B, amber lifts to #E39A3C. Texture halves in strength.
- Body text never sits below 4.5:1. Muted labels use full-opacity #58728D, not faded ink.

8. Typography direction

Inter Tight throughout, in four weights: 400, 500, 600 and nothing heavier. Numbers are always tabular so columns line up like print.

ROLE	SPEC	USED FOR
Hero amount	56/1.0, 600, –4% tracking	Spent this month
Screen title	24/1.2, 500	Review, Insights, Settings
Row title	15.5/1.3, 500	Merchant name, category name
Row amount	15.5/1.3, 600, tabular	Right edge of every row
Meta	12/1.4, 400, muted	Category · date, counts
Section label	11/1.0, 600, +16% tracking, caps	Top spending, Recent spending
Stamp	12/1.0, 600, +10% tracking, caps	4 need review

9. Component system

Eleven components carry the whole app. If a screen needs a twelfth, question the screen first.

COMPONENT	WHAT IT IS	RULE
Month header	Wordmark plus month pills	Two months visible, rest in Months
Hero total	Label, big amount, payment count	One per screen, tappable
Review stamp	Dashed amber outline, dot, count	Hidden at zero
Share bar row	Category, 8px bar, percent	Three on Home, all in Insights
Payment row	Initial, name, category · date, amount	56px tall, whole row taps
Tape band	Full-width #F2EDE3 section with rules	Max one per screen
Section label	Small caps label over a list	Two words, no icon
Count line	Counted, not counted, need review	Every number opens a list
Choice sheet	Bottom sheet of plain options	Reachable, one decision each
Rule card	"Swiggy → Food", count of payments	Made from a real correction
Bottom bar	Home · Months · Search · Settings	Words, four items, no badges

Motion. 200–300ms ease-out. Sheets rise, lists cross-fade, a cleared review fades its stamp out over 300ms. Nothing bounces, nothing slides sideways.

10. Screen guidance

Home

Month pills, spent this month, payment count, review stamp, one tape band of top spending, recent spending, a quiet "not counted" line, bottom bar. No greeting, no budget, no tips. Everything on this screen is tappable to its payments.

Review

One payment at a time, the reason in one line, and two or three plain choices — a category, Not spending, Keep as is. Progress reads "3 of 4". Finishing offers to make a rule. Empty state: "Nothing needs review" with the month's spend below it.

Insights

All categories as share bars, spending by month as a plain bar strip, and the biggest changes as two or three one-line facts ("Food up ₹3,200 from August"). Spending only — transfers, investments, refunds, rewards and income each get their own small total further down, clearly apart.

Transaction detail

Amount, merchant, date, category, account, and the alert it came from shown as the original text on a tape strip — this is where trust is earned. Actions: Edit transaction, Not spending, Make a rule. Any edit shows a small "Edited by you" mark.

Add

For cash and anything no alert covers. Amount pad first, then where and category — three taps to done, everything else optional. Cash payments get a small "Added by you" mark so the tape stays honest.

Settings

Privacy first and plainly: what Sorted reads, what it keeps, that nothing leaves the phone, and a one-tap export or delete of everything. Then Imports (SMS, Gmail — on or off, last read time), Categories, Auto-sorting rules, Appearance.

Auto-sorting rules

A list of rules in the user's own words — "Swiggy → Food, 34 payments". Each opens to change the category, apply to past payments, or turn off. Rules are only created from a correction the user already made, never from an empty builder.

11. Anti-patterns

- Donut charts, stacked cards, neon gradients, glass panels, mascots, streaks or scores.
- A total the user cannot open. A number without payments behind it is a rumour.
- Mixing transfers, investments, refunds, rewards or income into spending to make a bigger number.
- Red for uncertainty, or more than two amber marks on one screen.
- Accounting or system words in the interface — anything from the "never say" column.
- Explaining the app on the app. Paragraphs of reassurance, onboarding tips pinned to Home, privacy badges everywhere.

- Actions parked in the top corners where a thumb cannot reach, or hit targets under 44px.
- Heavy paper texture, torn edges, coffee stains, typewriter type — skeuomorphism instead of a cue.
- Silent auto-fixes, and notifications about anything except payments that need review.

12. Design review checklist

A screen ships when every line is true.

Answers its question in 3 seconds, without reading a sentence.

Every total, count and percent opens its payments.

Amber appears at most twice, and only for review.

No word from the "never say" column appears.

Primary action sits in the lower half; targets are 44px or more.

Body text passes 4.5:1 in light and dark.

Empty, loading and paused states still answer the question.

One number is clearly the biggest thing on screen.

Spending holds only spending.

Uncertainty is stated in one calm line with one tap to fix.

Every label is two or three plain words.

Tape cues are present but under 6% contrast.

Nothing implies a server, an account or a sync.

It could be read and used one-handed on a train.
